

C3 – PROTECTING SENIORS & DISABLED VS COLA REALITY

(Contradictions Ledger – Evidence Sheet)

I. THE OFFICIAL NARRATIVE ("WORDS")

Federal officials repeatedly claim that Social Security and COLA protect seniors and disabled Americans from inflation. Common statements include:

- Seniors should be able to retire with economic security and dignity.
- COLA will help tens of millions keep up with expenses.
- Seniors will get ahead of inflation and have breathing room.
- Medicare premiums going down plus benefits going up provides peace of mind.
- The government is committed to protecting Social Security and keeping the system strong.

These statements present a narrative that COLA maintains purchasing power.

II. HOUSEHOLD OUTCOMES ("OUTCOMES")

1. Medicare Premiums Reduce COLA Gains

Medicare Part B premiums rise yearly and consume a large part of COLA increases, reducing real benefit gains.

2. Senior Poverty (Supplemental Poverty Measure)

The Supplemental Poverty Measure, which accounts for medical and housing costs, shows significantly higher senior poverty than the official rate.

3. Senior Housing Cost Burden

Over 12 million older households spend more than 30 percent of income on housing, and millions spend more than half. This contradicts claims that benefits keep pace with cost of living.

4. Elderly Inflation (CPI-E) vs Worker Inflation (CPI-W)

COLA is tied to CPI-W, which reflects worker spending patterns. CPI-E, reflecting senior spending patterns, is consistently higher due to healthcare and housing. This means COLA undercompensates seniors.

5. Long-Run Buying Power Erosion

Social Security benefits have lost around 20 percent of buying power since 2010 because essential living costs rise faster than COLA adjustments.

III. THE CONTRADICTION

Public narratives promise protection: COLA keeps up with inflation, provides breathing room, and supports dignity in retirement. But government data shows:

- Higher senior poverty rates under realistic measures.
- Rising housing cost burdens for older renters.
- Medical premiums reducing real benefit value.
- Inflation indexes used for COLA failing to reflect senior spending patterns.
- Long-run erosion of true purchasing power.

One-sentence summary: COLA is described as protection, yet seniors fall further behind each year.

IV. HARM CHANNELS

- Income erosion due to COLA lagging behind senior inflation.
- Housing instability from rising rents and fixed incomes.
- Increased medical cost strain and skipped care.
- Greater food insecurity as essentials rise faster than benefits.
- Compounding long-term disadvantage for seniors on fixed incomes.

V. APA ROUTING (AGENCY USE)

- vSSA: CPI-W vs CPI-E mismatch makes COLA adjustments arbitrary relative to elderly costs.
- vHUD: Senior housing burden contradicts claims of affordability.
- vFED: Senior inflation exceeds aggregate inflation narratives.
- vHHS/CMS: Medicare costs undermine supposed protection.
- vIRS: Indexing formulas fail to reflect senior-specific inflation.

This establishes a clear gap between official COLA claims and measurable senior living costs.